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Sunday
October 4, 2026
THE HINDU

T. NAGAR

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‘Wait for road relaying continues’

P. SENTHIL KUMAR

Three weeks ago, an elderly woman fell on Fourth Main Road at VGN Nagar in Iyyappanthangal and sustained serious injuries. She fell because the road, already in a bad shape, had become slippery following the rains.

This road was last relaid in 2013. Except for this one, all roads in this region have been relaid in recent years. It may be noted residents of VGN Nagar decided to boycott the recently held Assembly elections as they were disenchanted with the fact that this road had not been relaid.

However, we gave up our resolve when Panchayat officials promised that the road would be relaid in three months and persuaded us to call off the boycott. We yielded to their request and exercised our franchise in the elections. As per the officials’ assurance the road should have been relaid by this July. Two months have passed by but the road has not been relaid and the North East monsoon is round the corner.

P. Senthil Kumar is a resident of Iyyappanthangal

Unfriendly footpath



T. GUNASEELAN

Some sections of the footpath on Pantheon Road in Egmore are unfriendly to pedestrians. On the stretch opposite Government Hospital for Women & Children, the debris of dug-up road has been dumped on the footpath.

Besides, the open manhole of a stormwater drain poses a threat to pedestrians’ safety. This spot is near Srirangam Avenue. It has been covered with a wooden board and a reflective cone placed nearby to alert passersby.

Further, telecommunication cables lie low on the stretch of the footpath under the flyover, that is from Srirangam Avenue to KVM Tower. The images were taken on September 30, 2026.

T. Gunaseelan is a resident of Ambattur





Key road in KK Nagar poses a threat

VANITHA PAULCHAMY

The stretch of Anna Main Road in K.K. Nagar near K.K. Nagar bus depot and ESI Hospital is battered. The road that was dug up for a civic work a few months ago has not been restored to this day.

It may be noted pedestrians cannot use the footpaths on Anna Main Road as they are plagued by encroachments. They walk on the road margins. As the road is in a bad shape, motorists tend to drive on the road margins also exposing pedestrians to risk, especially during peak hours. A patchwork should be carried out at the earliest as north-east monsoon is round the corner.

Vanitha Paulchamy is a resident of Saligramam



Attack on MTC conductor: preventive measures needed

B. ANNAPOORANI

Recently, I came across a newspaper article about a group of students assaulting a conductor of a Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) bus plying from Iyyappathangal to Royapuram.

The students were travelling on the footboard. The conductor requested them to come inside to close the doors. They refused to come in and continued to travel on the footboard.

The students subsequently argued with the conductor and attacked him. This incident is highly condemnable. In addition, MTC should take a lesson from this. The MTC should take serious note of this incident, increase the frequency of bus services during rush hour, especially the students’ special buses, and deploy police personnel to protect its crew members and the public.

B. Annapoorani is a resident of Porur

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A HOBBY EVOLVES TO MEET GEN ZERS

Advances in technology, easier licensing procedures and affordability are among the factors that make amateur radio attractive to youngsters, even those still in school. Here are perspectives of amateur radio enthusiasts and a seller of hobby-related equipment from Chennai **P2**



NEVER TOO LATE TO START AFRESH

Chennai resident Seshadri Sukumar kickstarted a career in sports photography, mid-life, turning his back on the familiar and the comfortable and that has made all the difference. Aged 71, he is right now covering the 20th Asian Games in Japan **P4**

Deadly 'gaps' at Guindy railway station

P. SATHYANARAYANAN

Recently, at Guindy railway terminal, an alert Railway Protection Force (RPF) personnel pulled a senior citizen to safety after the latter had fallen into the gap between the train and the platform. The train dragged him for a few metres

Mainline Electrical Multiple Units should not be operated on suburban train tracks.

The platforms are constructed in such a way that there is a huge gap between the entry/exit area of the train and the platform. The platforms at St. Thomas Mount railway station are similarly dangerous.

Commuters have to watch their steps while entraining and detraining.

In addition, the trains halt at the station for only 30 seconds. The train should not move until the station master and the railway staff raise and wave the green flag. Railway staff should be deployed at various points of the platform.

P. Sathyanarayanan is a veteran social activist, and a long-time resident of Guindy

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Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@ thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number.



'Chaos reigns at key junction in Virugambakkam'

S.N. RAJARAM

The Vembuli Amman Kovil junction in Virugambakkam on Arcot Road is a busy one but poorly regulated. The junction is at the intersection of Vembuli Amman Kovil Street, AVM Avenue First Main Road, and Arcot Road. Pedestrians find it difficult to cross this chaotic spot. A pedestrian signal is badly needed here.

S.N. Rajaram is a resident of Saligramam



The Vembuli Amman Kovil junction on Arcot Road.
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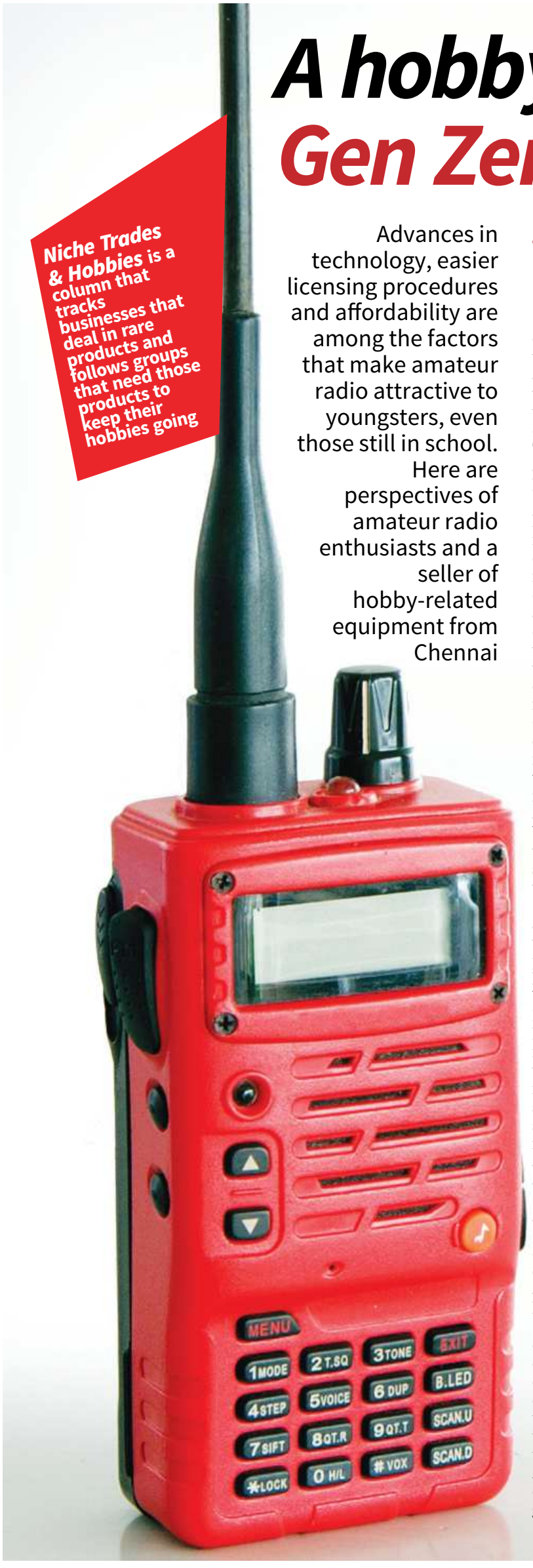
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Niche Trades & Hobbies is a column that tracks businesses that deal in rare products and follows groups that need those products to keep their hobbies going

A hobby evolves to meet Gen Zers on their terms

Advances in technology, easier licensing procedures and affordability are among the factors that make amateur radio attractive to youngsters, even those still in school. Here are perspectives of amateur radio enthusiasts and a seller of hobby-related equipment from Chennai



LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

There is usually an apocalyptic air to how Ham radio is perceived. The Ham radio enthusiast is readily visualised as trudging into a land overtaken by a massive disaster and where all technology-based communication lines outside the amateur-radio sphere have broken down. The enthusiast has morphed into a saviour, connecting with a fellow hobbyist elsewhere in the "universe" and communicating a local situation, dire and distressing, amidst the static and crackle of radio communication, to reach help to the suffering. This description is indeed fact-aligned. Ham radio enthusiasts do take centre stage during disasters. One witnessed that during the Kerala floods of 2018 and closer home, in the harrowing first week of December 2015 in Chennai. But distress communication is only one of the things riding on amateur radio air waves. Net sessions (as on-air meetups of Ham radio hobbyists are known) are also defined by banter, in fact, more by small talk than SOS calls. And do not be surprised if the banter is punctuated with Gen Z lingo.

N. Deepan (call sign VU2DPN), a key member of Madras Amatuer Radio Society (MARS), points out that the Ham radio hobby has never been as accessible to youngsters as it is now. From licensing to practising the hobby, the procedures of initiation and the operation of the equipment have become ridiculously simple. Having seen 63 summers and getting started on the hobby around four decades ago, Deepan is at a vantage point to talk about the hobby's evolution.

The Wireless Planning and Coordination wing (WPC) is responsible for conducting Amateur Station Operator's Certificate (ASOC) examination and issuing the license.

Deepan underlines the examinations have become simpler as technology has organically taken certain "subjects" off the table. And the removal of this barrier encourages the entry of youngsters. Anyone aged 12 and above can appear for the exam and get the license. "Where it took one or two years to get a license, it takes approximately one month," observes Deepan, noting that objective questions have replaced the earlier pattern of examination.

And the new license holder can hit the ground running, the process of getting started on the hobby also having become facile. EchoLink, Z3 DMR, and Droidstar allow licensed operators to communicate using just a phone with other amateur radio enthusiasts. Once the license is validated, usually within 24 hours, the software can be used. And that obviates the need to invest in ham radio equipment; that can wait. Deepan has seen the ham radio equipment move from valves to transistors, ICs and now Software Defined Radio (SDR). With advancing technology, the equipment has shrunk, and so has their prices. Deepan attributes the fall in prices to the shift from imported equipment to local dealerships (to sell ham radio equipment, a dealer's license is required).

That brings us to someone like Gaurav Srivatsava and his wife Shivangi Gaurav, both ham radio license holders and diehard enthusiasts, and beyond that, owners of Radio Brewery in Iyyapanthangal (radiobrewery.com), which sells amatuer radio equipment. Shivangi largely manages the business while Gaurav continues to work in the IT sector. Their own personal struggles in finding reliable and cost-effective equipment locally had crystallised into this business venture in 2018. Gaurav recalls that besides importing, Ham radio enthusiasts in Chennai were dependent on a couple of dealers in Delhi. The hobbyists would together buy in bulk to keep prices within their comfort range. Among those who encouraged them to start this business was Deepan, one of Gaurav's mentors and supporters.


Malini D

Among factors that augur well for the hobby, Gaurav says, is the portability of the ham radio gear. He recalls the time when valve radios, measuring six by six feet, "appropriated" a room in exchange for the joy of communicating on amateur radio air waves. Fast forward to now, a low-powered ham radio equipment can "fit into a small bread box". Deepan notes that even if one were to route their ham radio communication through an amateur radio satellite, the allied equipment, which includes SDR dongle, dish antenna and up converter or transverter, is easy on the back, being eminently portable. Both Deepan and Gaurav have noticed youngsters taking to the hobby. Gaurav points out his daughter Pari Gaurav (VI2JXB/ KN6GRI, US amateur radio identifier ID), 19 years old now, cleared the WPC examination at age 12. Deepan's daughter, Malini D. (VU3JJT) is also an avid ham radio enthusiast. Even youngsters without any precedent of ham radio engagement in their families are gravitating towards the hobby for the doors of communication it opens in various parts of the world. Deepan notes, "On the Net, all radio ham hobbyists connect and converse as equals."

To sum up, this hobby seems to have been made for Gen Zers (and the ones following them too) for two reasons. It is a generation that derives its strength and purpose from communication, even with those they will never meet in real life, and this hobby is geared to that. And two, this generation thrives on volunteering, and this hobby can provide opportunities for that during extremely harrowing times.

CH-TNE_A

How accessible is your community?



A scene from *Block A For Accessibility*

LIFFY THOMAS

How accessible is your apartment community? That's the central idea of this short film *Block A For Accessibility*, released with a private screening at PVR Satyam Cinemas on September 25. The 20-minute CBFC-certified film by YWTC (Yes, We Too Can!!!) Charitable Trust, in collaboration with Fiserv and United Way Mumbai as the CSR partner, is a story of care, community, and design.

The film revolves around Natarajan, an ageing father, who after starting to use a wheelchair keeps himself isolated from the vibrant life of his apartment complex because he does not want to trouble his son.

A sudden accident at the building's stairs becomes a turning point for the entire community.

The film follows the internal realisation of the association secretary and the decisive action of the builder.

Natarajan's character is played by a deaf person, Ravi Kumar. Voice was given by Umapathy, a wheelchair user. Most of the cast and crew are persons with disabilities, including the director. The film has sign language interpretations along with subtitles.

The film addresses a universal civic necessity: accessible housing that accommodates an ageing population and ensures people of all abilities live with independence and dignity.

For a screening of "Block A For Accessibility" at your apartment complex/workplace, write to yeswetoocan@gmail.com

Handrails: a silver jubilee gift



Not many residents at Raheja Regency, a 25-year-old apartment community in MRC Nagar, likely know the two people who were instrumental in getting handrails installed at strategic points in the society recently. Nonagenarian Arjun Krishna and septuagenarian Vasantha Arjun were too modest to talk about this accessibility feature and agreed to give their names after much prodding by this journalist.

One of the earliest residents of this gated community, when the couple were part of the resident association, they got handrails fixed at most of the blocks some 20 years ago. These have been patronised by all, especially the senior citizens. But the community could do with some more, and the couple themselves have experienced the practical difficulty in not having them.

"One of the ladies has even fallen not having a railing to hold on to it," says Vasantha. The couple sponsored the entire cost of installing the handrailings at some new locations as a gift to the community that has been their home for the last 25 years (the couple marked 25 years of staying in the community this June).

Pool lift: for easy swimming

Madhavi Latha Prathigudupu's day is not complete without accessing the swimming pool at her gated community in Arumbakkam. Since 2022, what makes this common amenity accessible for this para-athlete is the pool lift that was incorporated.

The swimming champion cannot do without being in the pool and her late father had to help her get into the waters. She convinced Triumph Apartments, a community with 108 flats where she owns one, to make the pool accessible. "Before installing the pool lift, we had a demonstration done by the manufacturer with the committee members to get their approval," says Madhavi, president of YWTC Charitable Trust.

Today, she goes independently into the pool (she controls the lift pool through a remote) and most importantly has raised the importance of



having inclusive amenities at gated communities not just for those with disabilities but even for use by the elderly. There was no ramp when she moved in to the community; the association did not just construct one for access to her block but made the improvisation at other towers as well.

Accessibility standards of the National Building Code insist on a barrier-free built environment and all common facilities accessible to all people. "It's your right, so ask the builder for such accessible features before investing in a flat," she adds.

Sensory park: designed by special parents



In August, the Community Living Association for Parents of Special Citizens (CLAPS) celebrated four years of moving into an inclusively designed campus at Tiruvallur, near Poondi reservoir.

A group of 50 parents of young adults with special needs got together to conceptualise such a model in a 8.5 acre residential campus that comes with a host of universally designed and accessible amenities.

Latha Krishnan and Vaijayanthi Srinivasan, both special parents, say the activity centre, swimming pool, and sensory park are the most popular among the young adults aged 20 and above.

Unlike the apartment communities where they faced many challenges, here everything is customised in keeping with the different needs of the children, a majority are on the spectrum, some with Down's Syndrome and intellectually disability.

The sensory park, for instance, is a hit for those with autism and has equipment with different textures. The activity centre allows them choose programmes as per one's moods and likes. To oversee the children, there are many external professionals, including the warden, supervisor and activity head.



On A Gobal Stage
is a column about residents of Chennai currently in the spotlight at a global event

Never too late to start afresh

R. RAGU

In cricket, one regularly comes across teams that shift to a whole new lane in the second innings, with surprising progress, eclipsing their first-innings performance. And in that process, they bring immense joy and wonder to spectators.

Seshadri Sukumar has pulled off something similar to that.

Here are the details of 71-year-old Seshadri's second innings: a Press Information Bureau-accredited international sports photographer from Chennai and a Canon EOS Ambassador. He now has a reputation for "checking into" major international sporting events. As this article is being written, he is shooting images of sporting excellence at the 20th Asian Games, unfolding at Aichi Prefecture and Nagaya in Japan.



Before zooming in on what he is doing now, a quick run of his first innings: Sukumar had been working in the banking sector, being an official photographer with Indian Overseas Bank (IOB). He always had an intense desire to be a sports photographer, but that remained a desire for a drearily long time.

When retirement from corporate career was looming large, Sukumar took the plunge and started pursuing sports photography full steam ahead.

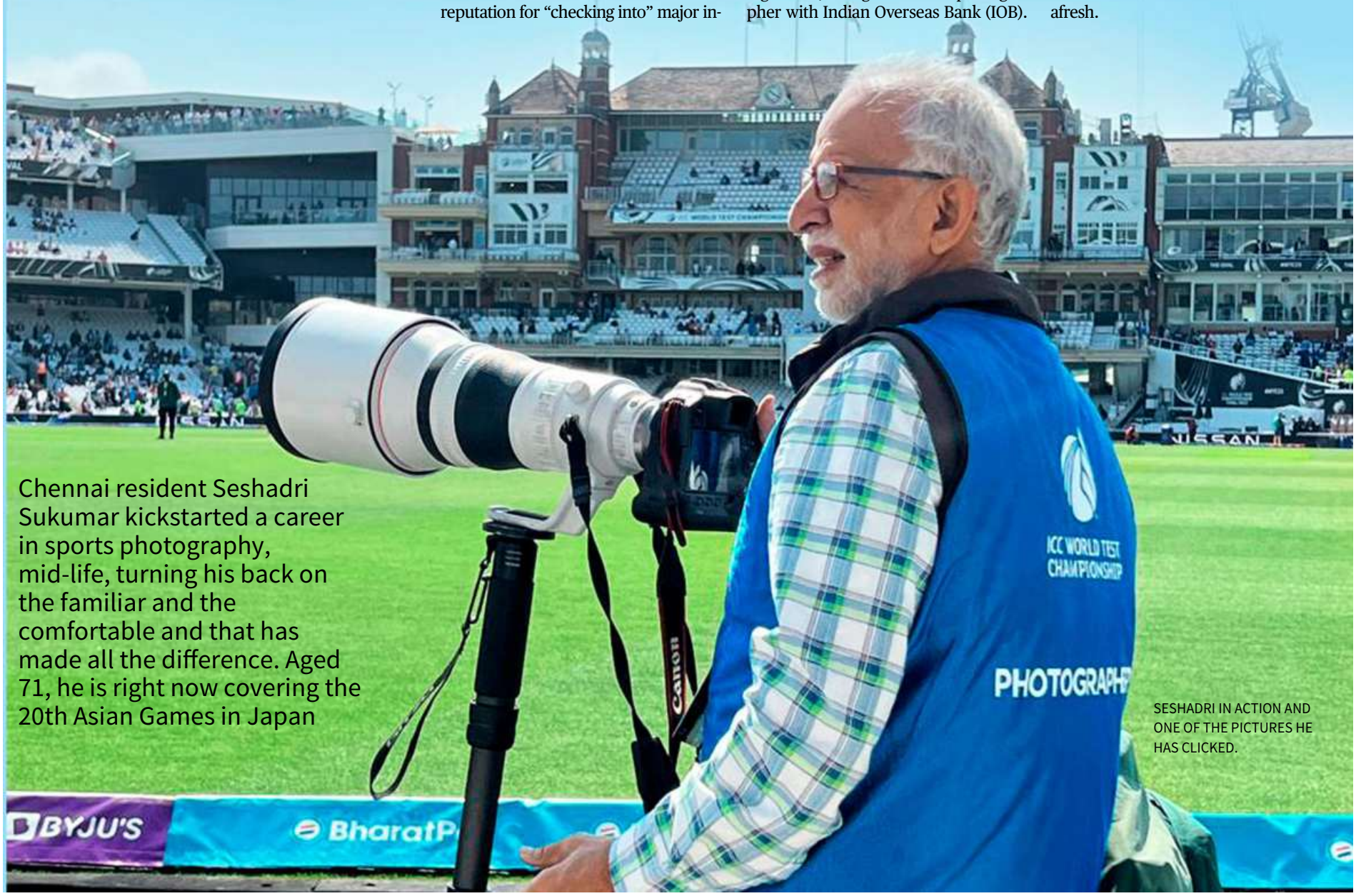
After Sukumar has been years into sports photography, in 2021, Sukumar's nephew shared a story about his uncle's passion for sports photography, online. Sukumar was 66 years old then and covering the Tokyo Olympic Games. And the story of how someone is flourishing in a career kickstarted mid-life caught the world's imagination.

Sukuamar's portfolio includes multiple Olympic Games, FIFA World Cups (including the most recent edition), ICC World Cups, Grand Slam tournaments, Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, NBA events, FINA World Championships, FIDE World Cups and MotoGP, among several other major sporting events.

Among his iconic photographs is one the Rio Olympics, one that captured the contrasting emotions of the winner and the loser; the photograph won his a gold medal from the Photographic Society of America (PSA).

Sukumar's professional photographs have been distributed through international wire services and stock photography libraries, including Alamy, Zuma Press, IMAGO Images, SOPA Images and Reuters Connect.

Sukumar's life and career are a reminder that it is never too late to start afresh.



Chennai resident Seshadri Sukumar kickstarted a career in sports photography, mid-life, turning his back on the familiar and the comfortable and that has made all the difference. Aged 71, he is right now covering the 20th Asian Games in Japan

SESHADRI IN ACTION AND ONE OF THE PICTURES HE HAS CLICKED.

Clothes distributed



The Karuna Club of Pon Vidyashram Senior Secondary School, organised a community outreach initiative.

According to a press release, the school students made voluntary contributions including clothes to old-age homes and orphanages.

The initiative was held as part of CBSE's SEWA (Social Empowerment through Work and Action) programme which aims to nurture empathy, compassion, and social responsibility among children.

The school is at Sapthagiri Nagar, Arcot Road, Valasaravakkam.

Navaratri workshop

Anita Raj is gearing up for the festive season. Following a stint in the corporate world, Anita decided to pursue her passion for art and creativity. As founder of C&D Art Studio, Anita curates and conduct beginner-friendly art workshops for corporates, educational institutions, retail brands, and private groups.

On September 27, she conducted a Madhubani workshop for doctors, in association with Dakshinam Sarees, at their Poes Garden, Alwarpet showroom. More than 20 doctors from various hospitals participated in this two-hour creative session, said a release. She has worked with various other brands and corporates.

As C&D Art Studio celebrates its fifth anniversary, it is planning a series of creative workshops for the upcoming festive season, including a navaratri-themed workshop. Dates and venue details will be announced shortly.

For details, call 99622 48000.

Instagram: @candd_art_studio

Rally on heart health

In observance of World Heart Day, VS Hospitals organised a four-km rally to spread awareness on heart health. On the occasion, the hospital launched its emergency helpline number 044 - 69698000.

According to a press release, former DGP C. Sylendra Babu flagged off the event at VS Hospitals, Tondiarpet, in the presence of Dr. S. Subramanian Chairman and Managing Director, VS Hospitals, Dr. S. Sundar, Medical Director, Muthu Subramanian, Executive Director, and Prassanna Srinivasan, Group COO.

Sylendra Babu, in his address, stressed on the importance of physical activity to be healthy. Close to 300 people took part including healthcare professionals and members of the public.



Donate your Golu *padi*



Chennai-based Thuvakkam wants families who are not planning to arrange the golu steps (*padi)* or have them stacked on their loft to give it to them. The NGO will be using them to showcases projects in the field of social, environment, conversation and volunteering, some of the main areas they have been working on. The steps will be collected from the houses of residents.

This Navarathri celebration-cum-golu display is happening from October 11 to 20; 6 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. at Thuvakkam head office in Alwarthirunagar. Public are welcome to come and see the display.

For details, call 98844 03762 / +91 98844 03749

Strengthening academia-industry connection



B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and Technology recently hosted an international industry collaboration and offer letter presentation ceremony with Crescent Global Outreach Mission (CGOM) and ADEEB Group, marking a significant step toward strengthening international industry-academia partnerships and creating global career opportunities for students. Ansari Wahid, Chief Executive Officer, ADEEB Group, Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates, was the chief guest.

The ceremony focused on strengthening international industry collaboration and enhancing students' exposure to global employment opportunities. Through this association, the institution is creating avenues for students to connect with international organisations, understand global industry expectations, and develop the skills needed to build successful careers beyond national boundaries, a release said.

A key highlight of the programme was the presentation of offer letters to the selected students.

The interactions emphasised the importance of industry-academia collaboration, international exposure, employability enhancement, and global career development in preparing students for the evolving demands of the international workforce, the release added.

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Book on Charles Kennet released



The 200th birth anniversary of missionary Charles Egbert Kennet, who made significant contributions to Christian history in the 19th century, was commemorated with a book release at the Tamil Nadu Archives, Kennet Lane, recently.

Organised by the Christian Historical Society, the book authored by V. B. Ganesan was released by writer and Assistant Editor of Tamil Nadu Archives Vennila. The first and second copies were received by Tamilselvan, Editor, and Balachandran, Assistant Editor, Tamil Nadu Archives.

Manna Selvakumar delivered the welcome address, followed by a historical presentation by the author and felicitation address by Vennila. Later, participants took a historical walk through Kennet Lane and St. John the Baptist Church, where Kennet served for 16 years.

Rangarajapuram resident releases book on Yoga



A book titled "The Awakener of Kriya Yoga - This Book is your Weapon; A Biography of Sujatha Murugan" authored by Jeyalakshmi Chandrasekar was released recently.

According to a press release, Jeyalakshmi Chandrasekar is a student of Sujatha Murugan, a Yoga teacher.

Inspired by her own transformative journey through Yoga, the author felt an inner calling to document the service of her teacher who has touched the lives of many people.

The book celebrates the timeless values of compassion, discipline, humility, and service that form the foundation of Yogic living, adds the press release.

It was released by film director, K S Ravikumar in the presence of dental surgeon and orthodontist, Dr Preethi Udhayaraja at a hotel in Koyambedu.

The author believes this work became possible only through the blessings and guidance of the legendary Guru, Mahavatar Babaji, known for the revival of the ancient Kriya Yoga.

The author Jeyalakshmi Chandrasekar is a resident of Nagarjuna Nagar at Rangarajapuram. She can be reached at 9841722077.

The Yoga teacher Sujatha Murugan can be reached at 9941339966.

An awareness rally to fight mosquito breeding



Dwaraka Doss Goverdhan Doss Vaishnav College organised a dengue awareness programme in collaboration with Greater Chennai Corporation for the student community and the general public recently.

The programme featured a demonstration on mosquito breeding, a human chain to create awareness among students, and an awareness rally from the College to NSK Nagar, Anna Nagaar.

Principal Capt. S. Santhosh Baboo highlighted the concept of "Each One, Teach One" and urged students to take the responsibility of disseminating dengue-prevention messages to their families and the wider community. Sundhar Raj, Superintendent Engineer, threw light on the breeding of dengue mosquitoes and the measures to prevent it. Iniyan, Assistant Commissioner, explained the breeding patterns of mosquitoes and the techniques used to eradicate mosquito breeding sites. U. Sudha, Zonal Health Officer and College secretary Ashok Kumar Mundhra were among those who took part.

RmKV's innovations in silk saris

In its 102nd year, RmKV is launching 18 new innovations in silk saris this festive season. The special showcase 'Weaves & Wonders' in Chennai will offer visitors an opportunity to experience the stories first hand. The saris on display include Ragamala, Kalpavruksham, Koorai Kattam, Bel Jaal Lino, Rettai Kili, Poo Thoranam, Poo Gopuram, Mayil Thuttham Korvai, Golden Kagome, Japanese Bijinga, Muppagam Naturals, Kili Kodi Lino, Chevvandhi Kattam, Madras Kattam and Golden Pearl Kattam

The showcase traces RmKV's continuing exploration of the Madras kattam, reinterpreted across the Madras Kattam, Golden Pearl Kattam, and Chevvandhi Kattam saris.

